

Action plan 2024–2027

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1. Background

Centria University of Applied Sciences (hereon Centria) signed the Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment and joined the Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment on June 9th, 2023. We aim to ensure that the evaluation of research and researchers acknowledges diverse forms of research outputs, methodologies, and engagement, taking into account various career paths and individual circumstances while assessing the quality and impact of research. Full agreement can be accessed at: [CoARA agreement](#).

1.1. Research in universities of applied sciences in Finland

The need for CoARA agreement arises from challenges inherent in the academic research tradition, which differs from the research, development, and innovation (RDI) activities in universities of applied sciences (UAS). Due to the characteristics of UAS-driven RDI work, such as development-orientation, translationality and interdisciplinarity, the identified challenges underlying CoARA play a minor role in UASs. RDI activities are fundamentally applied research, where the important values are both the advancement of scientific knowledge and the acceptability and practical applicability of the results.

UASs in Finland hold a vital, statutory role in regional development, serving as integral partners in regional innovation ecosystems. Consequently, the emphasis on diversity of contributions, collaboration and societal impact in research, as outlined in the CoARA agreement, is ingrained in the fundamental identity of UASs.

The CoARA process offers an opportunity to underline the societal value of applied research, while also making visible and enhancing the practices associated with assessing research, researchers, and research organizations.

1.2. Centria University of Applied Sciences

As one of the most international universities in Finland, Centria integrates collaborations with international RDI partners, international degree and exchange students, and English-conducted degree programs and courses into its everyday operation. With a robust understanding of project work, the Centria manages over 100 ongoing development projects annually, engaging experienced researchers, teachers, and students.

Centria's RDI aims to boost the competitiveness of entities in the region and improve well-being of the community. Centria, despite constituting only around two percent of Finland's UAS students, plays a substantial role as a regional developer. The corresponding RDI turnover, at around five percent, underscores its impact beyond its size. RDI activities take place across all three campuses in Kokkola, Pietarsaari, and Ylivieska, thereby contributing to regional development in Central Ostrobothnia, Ostrobothnia, and Northern Ostrobothnia.

Centria's RDI organisation is structured into seven teams, each specializing in specific areas: Chemistry and Bioeconomy, Digitalisation, Production Technology, Entrepreneurship and Business, Well-being and Health, Pre-Awards and Networks, and Services. These teams house interdisciplinary research groups, composed of Centria's experts collaborating on specific research topics. Projects are designed and executed collaboratively across the boundaries of the research groups, often in conjunction with teaching activities.

The research groups serve as a means to effectively showcase Centria's key RDI expertise to partners, aiming to share the latest knowledge and technologies with regional, national and international stakeholders. Centria is dedicated to making the results of its RDI activities readily accessible to the region's stakeholders. In instances where feasible, project outcomes are transformed into services or commercialized for external stakeholder use. The Services team takes charge of organizing development and training services.

As Centria's RDI activities continue to grow, there is a need to review and further develop RDI evaluation processes. The CoARA framework offers a well-suited structure for this purpose.

2. Objectives

In accordance with CoARA, Centria aims to evaluate and update the assessment practices on three levels:

1) Research

We must ensure that Centria's research assessment practices primarily rely on qualitative methodologies that are supported with responsible use of quantitative indicators. A key focus should be on motivating employees to engage in RDI activities that yield significant societal impact, adhere to the highest standards of quality, and enhance collaboration and openness. Currently, the evaluation of research within UASs diverges from academic research tradition, avoiding dependence on journal- and publication-based metrics, or similar numerical benchmarks. Nonetheless, it remains crucial to proactively safeguard against the potential adoption of inappropriate quantitative assessment practices in the future either.

2) Researchers and other persons working on research

The term 'researcher' encompasses all individuals participating in RDI activities across various roles. Centria is committed to ensuring transparent and fair evaluation of individual researchers and other research-related personnel, and already recognises the diversity of contributions to research, such as societal impact, business and academic networks, research orientation, project expertise and teaching. We are currently updating the career path model to accommodate a broader range of RDI career opportunities. As part of this reform, we will review the evaluation process and, where necessary, consider novel strategies and tools for researcher assessment.

3) Research Organizations

Finland is internationally recognized as a forerunner in advancing responsible research and researcher assessment, with longstanding national collaboration coordinated by Federation of Finnish Learned Societies (Tieteellisten seurain valtuuskunta, TSV). The CoARA agreement aligns with Finland's previously published national recommendations, introducing a schedule for implementing reforms.

Furthermore, Centria undergoes various regular evaluations from authorities and RDI funding bodies, with our funding being directly influenced by the results of these assessments. We welcome the opportunity provided by CoARA to underscore the significance of applied research and elevate the profile of UASs at the EU level as competent project partners and coordinators of applied research projects.

3. Overview of actions

	Action	Deadline
1	Completing and publishing the staff policy	30.6.2024
2	Publishing the research groups' actions plans on Centria's websites	31.12.2024
3	Establishing a peer review process among strategic higher education partners	31.12.2027
4	Developing a framework for competence management to raise scientific standards and a process for the internal visibility of competences within Centria	31.12.2027
5	Bringing qualitative indicators to management reporting when raising the scientific standards of Centria.	31.12.2027
6	Ensuring the appropriate use of quantitative indicators in the development of doctoral education capability of Centria. In the doctoral education in UAS, interdisciplinarity, societal impact and networks are emphasized.	31.12.2027
7	Emphasising qualitative indicators alongside the responsible use of quantitative indicators in the partnership policy	30.6.2024
8	Securing sufficient resources to plan and implement the organisational changes defined in the CoARA commitments.	31.12.2027
9	Exchanging practices and experiences to enable mutual learning and to promote CoARA objectives within and beyond the CoARA coalition	31.12.2027
10	Developing a framework to assessing societal impact across Centria's all activities	31.12.2027
11	Communicating the progress of the CoARA commitment process and raising awareness of its significance through various channels	31.12.2027
12	Monitoring the number of open data sets distributed by Centria in the open access repositories	31.12.2027
13	Providing external researchers with access to Centria's research(er) evaluation data for research purposes when requested and where possible	31.12.2027

ANNEX: Gap analysis

	Commitment in the Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment	State of play at Centria UAS in March 2024	Objectives and actions 2024–2027
1	Recognise the diversity of contributions to, and careers in, research in accordance with the needs and nature of the research	Candidates are evaluated based on their competencies rather than solely on their scientific merits. Alongside subject-matter expertise, factors such as professional networks, regional knowledge, experience in RDI projects, prior teaching engagements, and pedagogical qualifications are integral considerations in the selection process. The recruitment principles are outlined in Centria's HR policy, which will be finalized in spring 2024. Research work at Centria entails diverse roles with varying demands and content. The level of demand influences the salary grade of individuals. Competency requirements corresponding to different roles are detailed in Centria's career path framework for all staff, encompassing roles in RDI, teaching, and support services. This model is distributed to staff members via the intranet platform.	The staff policy is scheduled for completion in spring 2024 (Action 1). Upon its publication, Centria is fulfilling this commitment.
2	Base research assessment primarily on qualitative evaluation for which peer review is central, supported by responsible use of quantitative indicators	RDI project evaluation Centria sets qualitative and quantitative targets and metrics for RDI projects, evaluating their achievement upon completion. Objectives and outcomes are documented in project setting and closure forms. Qualitative goals include impact and sustainability evaluation, integration of RDI and teaching, and project result exploitation. Quantitative metrics encompass factors like participant numbers (companies, individuals), budget, thesis production, and student involvement. Thus, the responsible use of quantitative indicators in the evaluation of research is already taking place. In addition, Centria has an open science policy for RDI actions. Each project has a steering group to assess progress and provide feedback. Research group evaluation The research groups have drawn up a long-term action plan, the progress of which they assess in an annual self-evaluation report.	The research groups' action plans will be published on the research groups' websites by the end of 2024. (Action 2) Peer review among strategic higher education partners will be implemented by the end of 2027. (Action 3) Centria's new strategy for 2025–2028 includes the objective of raising scientific standards. The framework for competence management is being developed as part of the strategy implementation. (Action 4) Qualitative indicators will be brought into reporting alongside financial indicators. (Action 5)

3	Abandon inappropriate uses in research assessment of journal- and publication-based metrics, in particular inappropriate uses of Journal Impact Factor (JIF) and h-index	Quantitative journal metrics are not used inappropriately in research(er) assessment.	Centria is already meeting this commitment. Additionally, when developing doctoral education capability, we will ensure that quantitative indicators are not misapplied either in the future. (Action 6)
4	Avoid the use of rankings of research organisations in research assessment	Rankings are not used in research organisation assessment.	Centria is already meeting this commitment. Furthermore, Centria is preparing a partnership policy to be finalised in spring 2024, which will include criteria for the selection of partner universities, with an emphasis on qualitative indicators alongside the responsible use of quantitative indicators. (Action 7)
5	Commit resources to reforming research assessment as is needed to achieve the organisational changes committed to	Centria has allocated resources for planning and implementing the CoARA action plan. Expertise needed is available inside Centria's units, in particular the RDI Department, the HR Department, and Administration Department.	The development measures of CoARA will be incorporated into Centria's annual strategy-based action plan, ensuring they are not handled as separate initiatives. (Action 8)
6	Review and develop research assessment criteria, tools and processes 6.1. CRITERIA FOR UNITS AND INSTITUTIONS With the direct involvement of research organisations and researchers at all career stages, review and develop criteria for assessing research units and research performing organisations, while promoting interoperability	6.1. CRITERIA FOR UNITS AND INSTITUTIONS Centria representatives are actively involved in various national groups and networks whose activities support the objectives of CoARA. These groups include: - The Rectors' Conference of Finnish Universities of Applied Sciences (Arene) - The Finnish Association of Research Managers and Administrators (Finn-ARMA) - The Network of Open RDI and Learning (RDIL) in Finnish Universities of Applied Sciences - The DMP Consortium (collaborative network to promote research data management planning in Finland)	6.1 CRITERIA FOR UNITS AND INSTITUTIONS Centria continues to participate in current groups and networks, thereby promoting the objectives of CoARA. (Action 9)

	6.2 CRITERIA FOR PROJECTS AND RESEARCHERS With the direct involvement of researchers at all career stages, review and develop criteria, tools and processes for the assessment of research projects, research teams and researchers that are adapted to their context of application	- The Network of Research Integrity Advisers operating under the Finnish National Board of Research Integrity (TENK) In addition, Centria contributes to the development requests of The Finnish Education Evaluation Centre (FINEEC) 6.2 CRITERIA FOR PROJECTS AND RESEARCHERS Processes for evaluating research and researchers within Centria have been identified, but they are currently separate.	6.2. CRITERIA FOR PROJECTS AND RESEARCHERS Centria's new strategy for 2025–2028 includes a development agenda focused on impact and foresight. The goal is to mainstream impact thinking across all activities and develop a framework for assessing societal impact. (Action 10) Additionally, an integrated framework will be developed to evaluate individual researchers, research teams, and RDI activities comprehensively. Furthermore, as part of the competency management framework, a process is being established to promote the internal visibility of competences within Centria. (Action 4)
7	Raise awareness of research assessment reform and provide transparent communication, guidance, and training on assessment criteria and processes as well as their use	Existing communication channels are already in place for broad communication	Centria aims with internal dissemination to ensure that all employees understand the CoARA process, including its background and objectives. We share information about the CoARA process and its progress through various channels, such as the Centria website, the intranet, RDI events, and Centria Bulletin. The content covers project evaluation, researcher evaluation, and the unique characteristics of UAS as implementers within the CoARA framework. (Action 11)

8	Exchange practices and experiences to enable mutual learning within and beyond the Coalition	Centria has joined the Finnish National Chapter (NC) of CoARA, which is dedicated to helping its members implement CoARA commitments. The chapter also aims to engage a broader spectrum of stakeholders in CoARA activities at a national level. Furthermore, Centria is a member of the Finnish UAS network, which is an independent network operating separately from CoARA. Our involvement in this network allows us to participate in discussions and collaborations related to implementing CoARA principles. The Finnish UAS network acts as a continuous collaborative platform for research assessment development, even beyond the active working period of the CoARA National Chapter.	As a member of the Finnish National Chapter of CoARA and Finnish UAS network, Centria will contribute to knowledge sharing, mutual learning, and discussions from the perspective of UAS. (Action 9) Centria also disseminates information regarding its Centria CoARA action plan to international project consortia in which it participates as a partner. (Action 9)
9	Communicate progress made on adherence to the Principles and implementation of the Commitments		Centria will share information about the CoARA process and its progress through various channels, such as the Centria website, the intranet, RDI events, and the Centria Bulletin. (Action 11)
10	Evaluate practices, criteria and tools based on solid evidence and the state-of-the-art in research on research, and make data openly available for evidence gathering and research	The results of RDI activities are fundamentally open and public information, and Centria also adheres to the principles of open science. Additionally, Centria provides data to national authorities on its research activities.	The number of open data sets will be monitored (how much and which data sets Centria shares within the open access repositories). (Action 12) Where feasible, Centria will make its data available to researchers conducting research on research upon request. (Action 13)